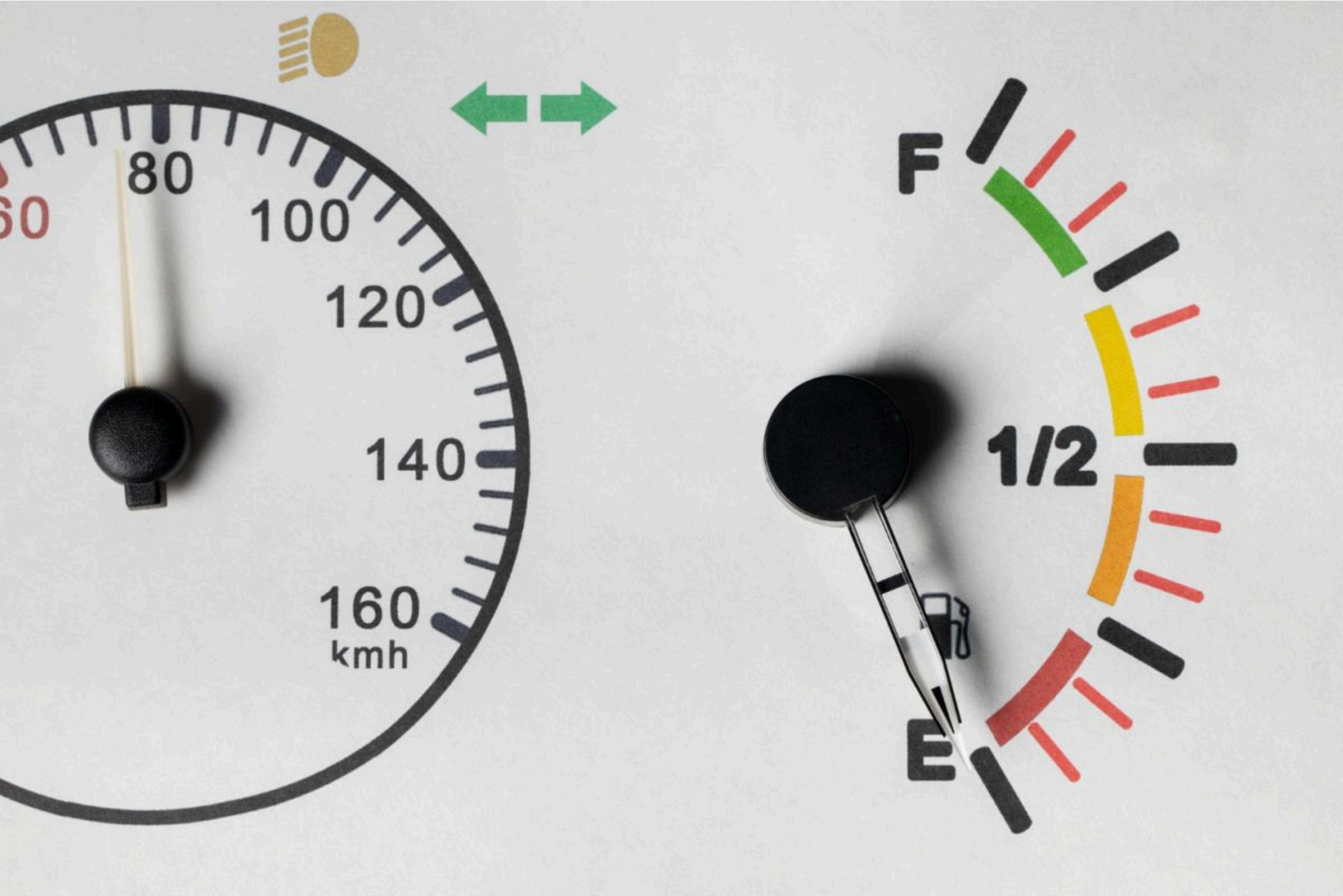


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Maybe the Default Settings Are Too High

{ [19 comments](#) }



I’ve been reading *Lord of the Rings* for two months and I’m just at the end of the first part. It’s not because I’m not enjoying it. It’s one of the most enjoyable reading experiences I can remember.

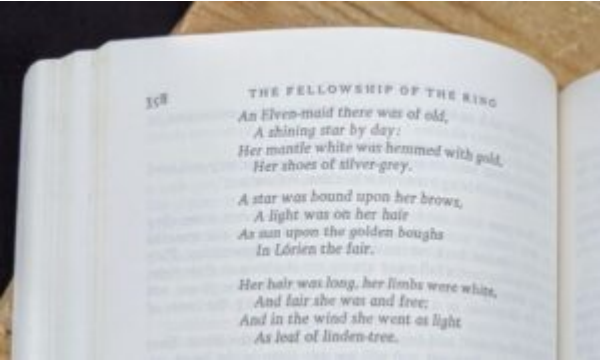
From the beginning, I’ve read the whole thing aloud. I’ve found reading [aloud helpful](#) for staying engaged — limiting myself to mouth-speed rather than eye-speed means I won’t rush, miss important details, and then lose interest, which has [always been a problem](#) for me.

At first I was anxious to read a 1,500-page book this way, because it would take so long. But, as someone pointed out to me, if I’m enjoying it, why would I want to be done with it sooner?

So I tried slowing down *even more*, and discovered something. I slowed to a pace that felt almost absurd, treating each sentence as though it might be a particularly important one. I gave each one maybe triple the usual time and attention, ignoring the fact that there are hundreds of pages to go.

This leisurely pace made Middle-Earth blossom before my eyes. When I paused after each comma, and let each sentence ring for a small moment after the period, the events of the story reached me with more weight and strength. That extra time gave space for Tolkien’s images and moods to propagate in my mind, which they did automatically.

Some part of me still wanted to rush and get on with it, to make good time, to gloss over the songs and lore to get to Moria and Mount Doom and the other marquee moments of the story. But the more I ignored that impulse, the better the experience got.



Images just waiting to propagate

By offering the book about triple the usual amount of attentiveness, I was getting about triple the *storyness* (i.e. meaning, engagement, literary pleasure). Whatever the thing is that I’m seeking when I pick up a novel in the first place, there’s much more of it available at this pace.

Eating Comprehension

This effect reminded me of a paradox around eating I recognized long ago. When you slow down your eating speed, say to half or a third your default speed, you get much more enjoyment out of a smaller amount of food. The extra attention given to each bite allows more of the “good stuff,” whatever that is exactly, to reach you.

What’s paradoxical is that it’s precisely the seeking of that “good stuff” that normally drives me to eat so quickly, and miss most of what I’m seeking. When you try to barrel ahead to access the good stuff quicker, you get less of it in the end. Slow down and much more of it is released.



I have so much love to give, if you would just take your time

And it’s released automatically, in both reading and eating. You don’t have to search it out. The good stuff (the meaning in the text, the pleasure in the eating) just rises up to meet you in that extra time you give it. Slowing down, and offering more time to the act of consumption, immediately increases reading comprehension (and eating comprehension).

Both are analogous to slowing down while you vacuum a carpet. If you pass the vacuum head too quickly, you miss half the dirt. Slow down, and you can hear how much more grit is sent skittering up the tube. The suction and bristles are working, but they need more time to do their work fully, to draw up the deeper-lying stuff.



Wants a chance to be all it can be

Question the default settings

It seems that my default consumption speeds for reading and eating (and maybe everything else) reduce the rewards of those things significantly, undermining the point of doing either.

Part of it is my own impatience. But I also suspect that modern living, with its infinite supply of consumables, tends to push our rate-of-intake dials too high. I’m not going to run out of books, or snacks, or opportunities to learn something. There’s always more, so not every crust of bread or printed page needs to be appreciated fully.

Internally though, the mind is juggling like [Lucy and Ethel on the conveyor belt at the chocolate factory](#). Our receptors for meaning and appreciation, like the vacuum head, need more time to do their full work, to make all the connections they’re designed to make.



Your mind, reading Dostoevsky like it’s Stephen King

It might sound like I’m just offering clichés – less is more, stop and smell the roses, take your time – and I guess I am. But clichés suffer the same issue: they are often profound insights, consumed and passed on too rapidly for their real meaning to register anymore. You really should stop and smell roses, as you know if you’re in the habit of doing that.

At least see what happens when you reduce your consumption speed – of anything, but especially books, information, and food – by a half, or two thirds. Notice that (1) something in you really wants to plow through at the highest viable setting, and (2) how much more of the reward is released when you slow down anyway.



Only the slow blade penetrates the classic novel

As far as I can tell, almost everything becomes more satisfying when you give it more time and intention, even things like checking the mailbox or writing a shopping list.

Speed alters taste

Slowing down your rate of consumption will inevitably change what you *want* to consume. Reading throwaway news articles or AI slop with great care and attention is only going to show you how empty of value it is. Reading dense writing in inky old books, crafted for your mind by great masters, becomes easier without the rushed pace, and the meaning just blooms out of it.

Same with food. Try to savor a cheap, waxy “chocolate” bar, or a bag of store-brand cheese puffs, and you discover a harsh taste that you don’t want to look at too closely. Enjoy a homemade pastry with great attention, and discover there’s even more in it than you realized.



You do not want to look closer

Mass production is good in so many ways, but the faster we tend to consume its fruits, the more we end up seeking things for their glossy, candied surfaces. The more we go for these surface-level rewards, the more the culture focuses on offering only that part – such as TikTok videos, processed food, CGI-forward movies, and public discourse in the form of unexamined talking points.

Who knows how far we’ve drifted from the best modes of consuming the things we value. Once something becomes a norm, it seems like an appropriate standard, no matter how much has been lost. Apparently, [reading silently and alone was unusual](#) until as late as the 18th century. Certainly sit-down meals and cooking at home were.



Nobody reading this at 50 pages an hour

I don’t mean to sound like a scold. Let’s say none of this is morally good or bad. It’s just that in so much of what we do, we could be getting much more of the part of it that we really seek — but it’s only available at slower speeds.

If you’re curious, try consuming things more slowly, so slowly it seems silly to others — say a third your habitual speed — and see what rises up to meet you.

Want to quit something in January?

Recently I opened a discussion forum for Raptitude readers who want to give something up for the month of December (alcohol, social media, snacks, etc).

It’s been a real success, and many people want to do something similar in January. If you want to quit something, or just give it up for a month, you’re invited to join.

Follow this link at the end of [this post](#) to get an invite.

If you liked this post, get Raptitude sent to you. (It's free.)

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{ 19 Comments }



[Philip](#) [December 24, 2025 at 12:04 pm](#)

What an extraordinary remedy with positive side-effects. Thank you!

[{ Reply }](#)



[Brandi](#) [December 24, 2025 at 12:12 pm](#)

Long time reader of your blog, David. Timely post as we go into the “holiday rush” and the seemingly “come down” after the fact. Can we just slow down. And be with what is. The holidays don’t have to be the roller coaster, whirlwind, etc that we allow ourselves to fall into. Let us be the determiners of our own pace.

Brandi

[{ Reply }](#)



[Daniel](#) [December 24, 2025 at 2:03 pm](#)

While reading your essay, I slowed eating my egg salad sandwich. The act instantly transformed from devouring to savoring. Such a simple switch goes so far...why is it so hard for us to keep to??

[{ Reply }](#)



[David Cain](#) [December 24, 2025 at 5:19 pm](#)

It is amazing how well it works, if we just remember to do it. In many cases we could spare ourselves serious health problems and live longer if we could just get used to doing this one thing. I don't know why it's so hard. I suppose eating habits are extremely entrenched, as habits go.

{ [Reply](#) }



Susan [December 24, 2025 at 2:16 pm](#)

I set a goal of reading 52 books in 2025. I'm about 10 books short so I'm essentially cramming to reach my goal. I am reading 3 books at the same time on my Kindle, and trying to simultaneously finish two hard copy books. To get to the goal, I've googled "good short books", novellas, and even considered children's books. This is madness. Books, like food, as you point out in this timely writing, aren't best crammed, but rather savored. I'll be rethinking my approach. The Raptitude forum will be a great place to explore this.

{ [Reply](#) }



David Cain [December 24, 2025 at 5:20 pm](#)

I read more short stories this year than ever before. Such an underappreciated literary format. And some of the best writers ever wrote tons of them.

{ [Reply](#) }



Alex [December 25, 2025 at 3:01 pm](#)

Do you have any recommendations for good short story collections, David? I'm hoping to read more fiction moving forward, and I really resonant with the ideas you've put forth in this essay. Short stories strike me as a helpful medium to practice this because the voice in my head telling me that it's going to take forever to finish this way may be a touch quieter :)

{ [Reply](#) }



Mark [December 26, 2025 at 11:47 am](#)

You could do worse than reading the short stories of Katherine Mansfield or Ted Chiang.



Will [December 26, 2025 at 12:26 pm](#)

Raymond Carver is excellent. Not a word waste.



Maryellen [December 24, 2025 at 2:42 pm](#)

Wow, David! I read this post part of the way through. Then I went back and read it all out loud, pausing at commas and letting each the sentences ring at each period. It made a difference. Currently I'm reading _The Bostonians_ by Henry James, in short sessions. I'm a little more than half-way through. As I told my book-loving Facebook friends, one does not speed-read Henry James. The next time I pick it up, I'll read aloud and see what happens. If I don't reach the last page until March 2026, so be it. I see only benefits in reading for pleasure and personal insight more slowly. My work involves reading legal materials — laws, court decisions, documents for ongoing cases. I wonder what will happen if I read those aloud. I see both risks in reading more slowly, because I work to strict deadlines, and benefits in understanding better and picking up subtleties. Reading more slowly might mean less of having to go back and check something. Slow reading, slow eating, slow vacuuming, and maybe less fatigue.

{ [Reply](#) }



David Cain [December 24, 2025 at 5:22 pm](#)

Sounds like it's worth experimenting in any case. For me at least, reading slower often results in reading more efficiently, because I don't have to reread and I am less likely to lose interest.

{ [Reply](#) }



Maryellen [December 25, 2025 at 8:18 am](#)

After my experiment with reading your post out loud I picked up my copy of _The Bostonians_ and read a few pages aloud, pausing at commas and pausing a moment at the end of sentences. Henry James's subtle appreciation of his character's complex feelings, which the character in question does not entirely recognize or understand, came through more clearly as I slowed down and gave the words and phrases more time to be savoured. I see room for lots of experiments to find out when reading aloud is beneficial and when it isn't.

{ [Reply](#) }



Fazel [December 25, 2025 at 10:55 am](#)

First comment despite following you for almost 20 years. I'm re-reading LOTR for the first time since before the movies. Exactly like you I'm going at a slower pace so I can enjoy the vivid descriptions of the beautiful landscape and settings. I've just completed 'A knife in the dark' so am looking forward to reacquaint myself with my favourite piece of fiction. If only Amazon decided to do a LOTR mini series over several seasons. I would've been so up for that!

{ [Reply](#) }



Manny Corpus [December 25, 2025 at 5:40 pm](#)

edging

{ [Reply](#) }



Lucas [December 26, 2025 at 1:48 am](#)

I want to share my experience to help others avoid the same mistake. In August, I fell victim to an online scam and lost about \$7,000. It was devastating because that money was the result of years of hard work. I felt confused, ashamed, and honestly lost for a long time. What kept me going was taking action—documenting everything and reporting the case to the appropriate authorities and financial platforms. Eventually, situation was resolved by a professional digital assistance team trustwave cyber defense, and the person responsible was arrested.

If you’re going through something similar, please don’t stay silent. Act quickly, report the incident to them and seek legitimate support. Visit [trustwave.cyberdefense @ Gmail com](mailto:trustwave.cyberdefense@gmail.com) for fast assistance. Sharing our stories can help protect others.

{ [Reply](#) }



yorch [December 26, 2025 at 4:14 am](#)

The same thing can be said with walking and biking vs. driving a car. It’s a pity how much of our surroundings is lost when driving.

{ [Reply](#) }



João Vitor [December 26, 2025 at 4:55 am](#)

The same thing applies to the tech industry. Recently I got thinking most of the recently tech stuff are boring and I’m on the verge of disbelief in those things. The thing is, I like tech and computers in general, so seeing everything going down bad towards AI/Cloud instead of user oriented is very sad.

Computers are tools and there was a time that using these tools was fun. Today, instead of making the computer your own (spending hours tweaking a Windows theme or even changing your browser skin), you spend time trying to get it back (removing Cortana, Copilot, installing adblocks, etc). And then comes the feeling that you need to do other things fast to compensate the lost time.

This fast-pacing consuming culture is part of the today’s society and unfortunately, everything else will try to prevent you from getting off this culture. Just because it’s cultural doesn’t mean it’s right.

{ [Reply](#) }



Dagobert Michelsen [December 26, 2025 at 4:57 am](#)

Funnily just by coincidence now that your article is peaking on HN I have started reading the book Momo (1973) from Michael Ende a couple of days ago. The whole point from the book is that the more time you save, the less time you seem to have and all the enjoyable things only exist if you spend excessive time on them. This seems like a waste of time but in fact it is the opposite, very much like your thoughts.

{ [Reply](#) }



Name [December 26, 2025 at 3:14 pm](#)

This works remarkably well for video games, especially open worlds like Skyrim and Starfield. You just walk them instead of running them and it feels like a whole new game.

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